EDEXCEL GCSE (9–1) HISTORY • OPTION 26/27

CONFLICT IN THE MIDDLE EAST

1945–1995

Key Topic 2: The escalating conflict, 1964–73



David Ben-Gurion reads the Declaration of Independence beneath the portrait of Theodor Herzl (Tel Aviv, 14 May 1948).

OFFICIAL COURSE TEXTBOOK

Enquiry: *"Why has peace proved so elusive in the Middle East?"*

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L1: KT 2.1 Enquiry: How Did Water, Border Raids, and Rhetoric Make a Second Arab-Israeli War Inevitable? (1964–1967)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Explain the significance of the 1964 Cairo Conference and the growth of Palestinian resistance groups.
- [ ] Describe the causes and consequences of the River Jordan water dispute and Syrian border clashes.
- [ ] Evaluate how the Samu raid (November 1966) and the Golan air battle (7 April 1967) created unstoppable momentum towards war.

In January 1964, Arab leaders met in Cairo to resolve two crises: Israel was pumping water out of the River Jordan, and Palestinians demanded their own state. Within three years, artillery battles and aerial dogfights had made a full-scale war inevitable.

Recall & Retrieval (Prior Learning: Key Topic 1)

1. What was the name of the 1917 British policy document supporting a "national home for the Jewish people" in Palestine?

2. What type of administrative control was granted to Britain over Palestine by the League of Nations in 1920?

3. Which building in Jerusalem was bombed by the militant group Irgun in July 1946, killing 91 people?

4. What was the number of the United Nations Resolution passed in November 1947 to partition Palestine?

5. On what date did David Ben-Gurion proclaim the establishment of the State of Israel?

6. Approximately how many Palestinian Arabs became refugees during the 1948–49 Arab-Israeli War?

7. What law passed by the Israeli Knesset in 1950 granted every Jewish person the right to settle in Israel?

8. Who became the President of Egypt in 1954 and emerged as the primary champion of Pan-Arab nationalism?

9. What vital international waterway did Nasser nationalise in July 1956, triggering the Suez Crisis?

10. Which two European powers secretly colluded with Israel to invade Egypt in October 1956?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: *Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?*

Cairo Conference (1964) | PLO (Palestine Liberation Organisation) | Fatah | National Water Carrier | Samu Raid (1966) | 7 April 1967 Dogfight

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

Source A: Archival Primary Photograph: Arab Heads of State at the First Arab League Summit in Cairo (January 1964) *Archival Evidence • Expand ▼*

[1.1] In January 1964, the heads of state of the Arab League gathered in Cairo at the invitation of Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser. The immediate catalyst for the summit was Israel's completion of the National Water Carrier—a massive engineering pipeline designed to pump water from the Sea of Galilee to irrigate farms in central Israel and the southern Negev desert. Arab governments viewed this project as an aggressive attempt to absorb more Jewish immigrants and strengthen Israel's economy. At Cairo (Source A), Arab leaders agreed on two major policies: they voted to create the Palestine Liberation Organisation (PLO) to give the Palestinian people an official political voice, and they approved a joint Arab plan to build canals diverting the headwaters of the River Jordan inside Syria and Lebanon, which would strip Israel of roughly one-third of its freshwater supply. [1.2] The dispute over water quickly turned into active warfare along the northern border. Between 1964 and 1966, Israeli tanks and aircraft repeatedly shelled Syrian construction sites and earth-moving machinery, bringing the Arab diversion scheme to a complete halt. At the exact same time, Palestinian nationalist guerrillas belonging to Fatah—led by Yasser Arafat—began staging hit-and-run sabotage operations across the armistice lines, targeting Israeli water pumps, railways, and border settlements. In February 1966, a radical military coup in Syria brought hardline officers to power in Damascus who openly pledged to sponsor Fatah and support a "popular liberation war" to destroy the state of Israel.

Q1. Using paragraphs [1.1] and [1.2] and Source A, explain the two main decisions made at the 1964 Cairo Conference and why the River Jordan dispute sparked military clashes.

Source B: Historical Topographical Map: The Syrian Armistice Line and Golan Heights Overlooking Israeli Settlements (1964–1967)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[2.1] Between 1965 and 1967, the border between northeastern Israel and Syria became the most dangerous frontier in the Middle East. Syrian artillery batteries perched atop the towering volcanic plateau of the Golan Heights held complete tactical dominance over the low-lying Israeli kibbutzim (farming communities) in the Hula Valley below. Syrian gunners routinely fired machine guns and artillery shells down at Israeli tractors attempting to cultivate fields within the disputed demilitarised border zones. Israeli farmers were forced to drive custom-armored tractors to plough their fields under fire, while Israeli school children were evacuated to sleep in reinforced underground concrete bomb shelters. (Source B) illustrates the commanding geographical position of the Syrian fortifications on the Golan Heights, showing why this frontier became a continuous combat zone. [2.2] In response to these border attacks and ongoing Fatah sabotage raids, the Israeli military High Command adopted a policy of aggressive retaliation. Israeli leaders, including Chief of Staff Yitzhak Rabin and Prime Minister Levi Eshkol, warned that Israel held host governments directly accountable for any guerrilla attacks launched from their territory. Rather than deterring raids, this hardline policy locked both sides into an escalating cycle of violence: every guerrilla landmine was answered by Israeli artillery barrages and air strikes, which in turn provoked Syrian counter-bombardments and calls across the Arab world for revenge.

Q2. Using Source B and paragraphs [2.1]–[2.2], explain why the geography of the Golan Heights gave Syria a commanding military advantage and why Israel adopted a policy of retaliation.

Source C: Archival Diplomatic Dispatch: The 7 April 1967 Air Battle and Arab Political Repercussions

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[3.1] By late 1966, this cycle of violence triggered two major military explosions that brought the Middle East to the brink of war. On 11 November 1966, an Israeli border patrol vehicle struck a Fatah landmine near the southern West Bank border, killing three Israeli soldiers. Although the guerrillas had crossed from

Jordan, King Hussein of Jordan had actively tried to suppress Fatah to avoid Israeli retaliation. Nevertheless, on 13 November 1966, Israeli forces launched a massive daytime reprisal attack on the West Bank town of Samu. Israeli armored forces destroyed dozens of houses and clashed fiercely with the Jordanian army, leaving 15 Jordanian soldiers and three civilians dead. The Samu raid provoked furious riots across the West Bank, with Palestinians denouncing King Hussein for failing to defend them and demanding weapons to fight Israel. [3.2] The decisive military clash occurred five months later on 7 April 1967 along the Syrian frontier. When Syrian gunners opened fire on an Israeli tractor working disputed land near Lake Tiberias, Israeli tanks and aircraft retaliated. The battle rapidly expanded into a massive aerial dogfight. Israeli Air Force Mirage jet fighters intercepted Syrian MiG-21s, pursuing them across the border and shooting down six Syrian jets in full view of spectators over Damascus. (Source C) records the intense humiliation felt in Damascus following this aerial defeat. Syrian radio broadcasts furiously accused President Nasser of Egypt of cowardice, taunting him for hiding behind United Nations peacekeepers in the Sinai while Syrian pilots were killed. By May 1967, Nasser felt his leadership of the Arab world was under direct threat, setting the stage for the fatal moves that led to the Six Day War.

Q3. Using paragraphs [3.1]–[3.2] and Source C, complete a comparative analysis explaining how both the Samu Raid and the 7 April 1967 air battle increased pressure on Arab leaders.

[4.1] By May 1967, the Middle East had reached a critical flashpoint. Three interconnected factors had created an inescapable crisis: first, the conflict over the River Jordan water supply had transformed natural resources into a justification for military strikes; second, the rise of independent Palestinian guerrilla groups like Fatah, backed by the radical Syrian government, guaranteed continuous border violence; and third, Israel's uncompromising policy of massive military retaliation ensured that local skirmishes escalated into major battles. [4.2] Historians emphasize that while neither Israeli leaders nor President Nasser actively wanted a full-scale war in the spring of 1967, both sides had painted themselves into diplomatic corners. When false Soviet intelligence arrived in Cairo in mid-May claiming Israel was massing twelve brigades to invade Syria, Nasser felt he had no choice but to march his army into the Sinai to defend his Arab allies. The regional escalation that began at the 1964 Cairo Conference had built a momentum that diplomacy could no longer restrain.

Q4. Explain one consequence of the 7 April 1967 aerial battle over the Golan Heights. [4 marks]

L2: KT 2.2 Enquiry: Why Was the Six-Day War Decided in Three Hours, and Did Nasser Intend to Fight? (May–June 1967)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Explain the sequence of events in May 1967 that made war unavoidable (Soviet reports, UNEF, Tiran).
- [ ] Describe the execution and decisive impact of Israel's pre-emptive dawn airstrike on 5 June 1967.
- [ ] Trace the three military campaigns and explain why Israel succeeded so rapidly in Sinai, the West Bank, and the Golan Heights.

> *On the morning of 5 June 1967, nearly 200 Israeli fighter jets flew low beneath radar over the Mediterranean. Within three hours, over 300 Egyptian aircraft lay burning on the tarmac. By Saturday evening, the map of the Middle East had been changed forever.*

Recall & Retrieval (Prior Learning: KT1 & KT2.1)

1. Where did Arab League leaders meet in January 1964 to coordinate policy against Israel?

2. What is the full name of the political organisation established in 1964 to represent the Palestinian people?

3. Which Palestinian nationalist guerrilla organisation was founded and led by Yasser Arafat?

4. What was the name of the Israeli engineering pipeline built to pump water from the Sea of Galilee across the country?

5. Which elevated territory was used by Syrian artillery to shell Israeli collective farms below?

6. In November 1966, Israeli forces launched a major reprisal raid on which West Bank village?

7. How many Syrian MiG fighter jets were shot down by the Israeli Air Force on 7 April 1967?

8. Which Egyptian leader nationalised the Suez Canal in 1956, becoming a hero of Pan-Arab nationalism?

9. What was the name of the armistice line drawn in 1949 after the first Arab-Israeli War?

10. Which international organisation passed Resolution 181 in 1947 to partition Palestine?

Vocabulary Check

The Golden Sentence: *Choose TWO terms from the word bank. Write ONE grammatically sophisticated, historically accurate sentence connecting them using a causal conjunction (because, although, or consequently):*

UNEF (UN Emergency Force) | Straits of Tiran | Pre-emptive Strike | Air Supremacy | West Bank | Western Wall

Teacher Model / Pupil Sentence:

[1.1] The crisis that ignited the Six Day War began on 13 May 1967, when the Soviet Union passed false intelligence reports to Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser claiming that Israel was massing twelve military brigades along the Syrian border for an imminent invasion. Although United Nations observers on the ground inspected the frontier and confirmed that no Israeli troop buildup existed, Nasser could not afford to look weak after months of Syrian taunts following the 7 April air battle. To restore his reputation as the undisputed champion of the Arab world, Nasser made three dramatic moves: he marched 100,000 Egyptian troops and 1,000 tanks into the Sinai Peninsula; on 16 May he ordered the immediate expulsion

of the United Nations Emergency Force (UNEF) peacekeepers who had secured the border since 1957; and on 22 May he announced the closure of the Straits of Tiran to Israeli shipping. [1.2] The closure of the Straits of Tiran was the fatal turning point. The straits were Israel's sole maritime gateway to Asia and East Africa through the southern port of Eilat, and the channel through which 90% of Israel's vital crude oil imports arrived. Back in 1957, Israel had officially notified the international community that closing the straits would be treated as an explicit act of war (casus belli). Tension spiked to fever pitch on 30 May 1967, when King Hussein of Jordan flew to Cairo to sign a mutual defense pact, placing the Jordanian army under Egyptian command, while Iraq joined the alliance shortly after. Encircled by hostile armies boasting publicly of driving Israel into the sea, the Israeli cabinet formed a national unity government, appointing war hero General Moshe Dayan as Minister of Defence, and concluded that striking first was the only way to avoid national destruction.

Q1. Using paragraphs [1.1] and [1.2], identify the three actions taken by President Nasser in May 1967 and explain why Israel viewed the closure of the Straits of Tiran as an act of war.

Source A: Archival Photograph: Destroyed Egyptian Jet Aircraft at Bir Gifgafa Airfield, Sinai (5 June 1967)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[2.1] At 7:45 am on Monday, 5 June 1967, Israel launched a meticulously planned pre-emptive dawn airstrike against Egyptian military airfields. Realising that Israel's small civilian reserve army could not remain mobilized indefinitely without economic collapse, Israeli military planners committed nearly all of their operational jet fighters—leaving only twelve aircraft behind to defend Israel's home skies. Israeli fighter-bombers flew out west over the Mediterranean Sea, skimming just thirty feet above the waves to stay beneath Egyptian radar detection, before looping inland into Egypt from the west at the exact moment Egyptian pilots were finishing breakfast and morning patrols had landed. [2.2] The surprise attack was an overwhelming tactical triumph. In waves lasting just over two hours, Israeli jets struck seventeen Egyptian airbases, dropping specialized rocket-boosted cratering bombs to destroy concrete runways before strafing parked combat aircraft with cannons. Over 300 Egyptian combat aircraft were destroyed on the ground, wiping out Egypt's air force before it could take off. When Syrian and Jordanian aircraft attempted to retaliate later that morning, Israeli jets struck their airfields as well, destroying a further 100 enemy planes. (Source A) shows the charred ruins of Egyptian MiG fighter jets on the airfield tarmac at Bir Gifgafa in the Sinai, demonstrating how total air supremacy was won in the opening hours of the conflict, leaving Arab ground troops completely exposed to air attack.

Q2. Using Source A and paragraphs [2.1]–[2.2], explain how the tactics of low-altitude flight, runway destruction, and surprise enabled Israel to achieve complete air supremacy.

Source B: Archival Primary Photograph: Israeli Paratroopers at the Western Wall, Jerusalem (David Rubinger, 7 June 1967)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[3.1] With total control of the skies established, the Israeli ground offensive swept across three separate combat fronts. In the Sinai Peninsula, three Israeli armored divisions, commanded by generals including Ariel Sharon, smashed through Egyptian fortified border positions. Deprived of air cover and receiving panicked, contradictory retreat orders from Cairo, the Egyptian army collapsed into a disordered retreat. Within four days, Israeli armored spearheads had reached the eastern bank of the Suez Canal, capturing thousands of Egyptian soldiers and destroying hundreds of tanks. [3.2] On the eastern front, Jordan had entered the war on the morning of 5 June by shelling Israeli positions in West Jerusalem and suburbs of Tel Aviv, ignoring Israeli diplomatic warnings to remain neutral. Israeli forces counter-attacked

immediately into the West Bank, surrounding Jordanian troops in Nablus, Bethlehem, and Hebron. On Wednesday, 7 June, Israeli paratroopers breached the Lions' Gate into the Old City of Jerusalem, capturing the Temple Mount and reaching the Western Wall—the holiest prayer site in Judaism, where Jews had been barred from praying under Jordanian rule since 1948. (Source B) captures the iconic photograph of Israeli paratroopers standing in silence and emotion at the foot of the Western Wall. Finally, on 9–10 June, Israeli infantry and armored units scaled the fortified cliffs of the Golan Heights, driving the Syrian army back to within forty miles of Damascus before a UN ceasefire ended the war.

Q3. Complete a structured grid detailing Israeli actions and territorial gains across the Sinai, West Bank, and Golan Heights fronts.

[4.1] In only six days of combat (5–10 June 1967), the strategic and political map of the Middle East was revolutionized. Israel lost fewer than 1,000 soldiers, while Arab armies suffered catastrophic losses: over 15,000 Egyptian, 6,000 Jordanian, and 1,000 Syrian soldiers were killed, and the bulk of their modern military equipment was destroyed. Israel had quadrupled its territorial footprint, creating a vast strategic buffer zone that included the Sinai Peninsula, Gaza Strip, West Bank, East Jerusalem, and the Golan Heights. [4.2] However, this triumph created complex long-term problems. By capturing the West Bank and Gaza Strip, Israel brought over one million Palestinian Arabs under military rule, triggering a fresh refugee exodus and fueling a new wave of Palestinian nationalism. While Israelis felt secure behind wide natural borders, the profound humiliation suffered by Egypt and Syria guaranteed that Arab leaders would dedicate their resources to preparing for a war of revenge.

Q4. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Six Day War (June 1967). [8 marks] You may use the following in your answer: • Nasser's closure of the Straits of Tiran (May 1967) • The pre-emptive Israeli air strike (5 June 1967) You must also use information of your own.

L3: KT 2.3 Enquiry: "Land for Peace" or Permanent Stalemate: How Did the 1967 Conquered Territories Transform the Conflict?

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Identify the five Occupied Territories and explain the humanitarian impact on Palestinian refugees.
- [ ] Explain the significance of the Khartoum Conference (August 1967) and the "Three Noes".
- [ ] Analyse the core principles and deliberate ambiguities of UN Security Council Resolution 242 (November 1967).

In the summer of 1967, Israel found itself ruling over one million Palestinians. In September, Arab leaders declared the "Three Noes" in Khartoum. In November, the UN passed Resolution 242 promising "Land for Peace"—yet its ambiguous words locked the region in stalemate.

Recall & Retrieval (Prior Learning: KT1 & KT2.2)

1. What international peacekeeping force was expelled from the Sinai Peninsula by Nasser in May 1967?

2. What narrow waterway did Nasser close on 22 May 1967, cutting off Israel's southern maritime trade?

3. On what date did Israel launch its pre-emptive dawn airstrike, destroying the Egyptian Air Force?

4. Who was appointed Israeli Minister of Defence just days before the outbreak of the Six Day War?

5. Which ancient holy site did Israeli paratroopers capture in East Jerusalem on 7 June 1967?

6. Which Syrian territory overlooking the Sea of Galilee was captured by Israeli forces on 9–10 June 1967?

7. What was the name of the Egyptian canal nationalised by Nasser in July 1956?

8. Which major superpower passed false intelligence reports to Egypt in May 1967 claiming Israel was massing troops?

9. What was the name of the armistice line drawn after the 1948–49 war that divided Israel from the West Bank?

10. Which international organisation established the partition plan in 1947 under Resolution 181?

Vocabulary Check

Conceptual Classification: *Categorise the terms from the word bank into the two historical boxes below:*

Occupied Territories | Khartoum Conference | The Three Noes | UN Resolution 242 | Land for Peace | Israeli Settlements

Power, Governance & Warfare	Economy, Trade & Society

Source A: Archival Primary Map: The Conquered Occupied Territories Following the Six-Day War (June 1967)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[1.1] In the weeks following the June 1967 ceasefire, the government of Israel confronted a dramatic transformation in its strategic reality. Israel was now in military control of vast territories (Source A): the entire Sinai Peninsula and the Gaza Strip from Egypt, the West Bank and East Jerusalem from Jordan, and the Golan Heights from Syria. Israel's total land area had quadrupled. Israeli military planners celebrated the creation of wide natural buffer zones—the wide expanse of the Sinai desert, the water barrier of the Suez Canal, the Jordan River valley, and the high cliffs of the Golan Heights—which made surprise ground attacks against Israel's heartland far more difficult. [1.2] However, this triumph created immediate humanitarian and political dilemmas. By occupying the West Bank and Gaza Strip, Israel brought over one million Palestinian Arabs under its direct military rule. Between 300,000 and 350,000 Palestinians fled or were displaced across the River Jordan into overcrowded refugee camps in Jordan during and immediately after the fighting. For many, this was their second displacement within twenty years, having previously fled during the 1948 war. Israel immediately annexed East Jerusalem, declaring the unified city its eternal capital, while placing the West Bank and Gaza under a military governor. Shortly afterwards, the first civilian Jewish settlements were established in strategic zones such as the Jordan Valley and Gush Etzion, beginning a process that would profoundly complicate any future territorial compromise.

Q1. Using Source A and paragraphs [1.1]–[1.2], list the five territories captured by Israel in June 1967 and describe the two main consequences for Palestinian refugees.

Source B: Archival Communiqué: The Khartoum Arab League Summit Resolution (1 September 1967)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[2.1] The scale of the Arab military defeat produced immense shock and humiliation across the Arab world. From 29 August to 1 September 1967, the heads of state of eight Arab nations gathered in Khartoum, the capital of Sudan, to coordinate their joint response. Moderate leaders, including King Hussein of Jordan, quietly urged a pragmatic diplomatic approach to negotiate the return of the captured territories. However, hardline sentiment dominated the conference. President Nasser of Egypt and Syrian leaders argued that offering political concessions or recognising Israel while Arab lands remained occupied would validate Israeli military aggression and humiliate the Arab nation permanently. [2.2] The conference ended with a categorical, unyielding resolution that became universally known as the "Three Noes" of Khartoum: "no peace with Israel, no recognition of Israel, no negotiations with it." (Source B) records the third clause of the Khartoum Communiqué, setting out the collective Arab rejection of direct peace talks. In Israel, the Khartoum declaration was received as definitive proof that Arab governments remained dedicated to Israel's total destruction, regardless of what territorial compromises Israel might offer. Consequently, the Israeli cabinet abandoned early ideas of offering land back in exchange for peace, hardening Israeli resolve to hold the Occupied Territories indefinitely.

Q2. Using Source B and paragraphs [2.1]–[2.2], explain what the "Three Noes" were and analyse how this declaration impacted Israeli policy.

Source C: Diplomatic Treaty Comparison: Article 1(i) of UN Security Council Resolution 242 in English and French

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[3.1] Alarmed that the Middle East remained an active battlefield that could drag the United States and the Soviet Union into a direct superpower collision, the United Nations Security Council spent months drafting a compromise framework. On 22 November 1967, the Security Council unanimously adopted Resolution 242, authored primarily by the British ambassador to the UN, Lord Caradon. Resolution 242 introduced the historic formula of "Land for Peace": it declared the inadmissibility of the acquisition of territory by

war and called for the "withdrawal of Israel armed forces from territories occupied in the recent conflict," in exchange for the termination of all states of belligerency and the acknowledgement of the right of every state in the area to live in peace within secure and recognised boundaries. [3.2] However, Resolution 242 contained a deliberate linguistic ambiguity that prevented its successful implementation. (Source C) contrasts the English text with the equally binding French translation. The English text called for Israeli withdrawal from "territories occupied," deliberately omitting the definite article "the." Israel and the United States argued this meant Israel was required to withdraw only from *some* territories, allowing minor border adjustments to ensure "secure and recognised boundaries." Conversely, Arab states pointed to the French version ("retrait des forces armées israéliennes des territoires occupés"), insisting that "des" meant *all* the occupied territories. Furthermore, the resolution referred to the displaced Palestinians only as "the refugee problem," completely ignoring their national aspirations for statehood.

Q3. Using Source C and paragraphs [3.1]–[3.2], explain the core principle of "Land for Peace" and how wording differences created diplomatic deadlock.

[4.1] In the long term, the aftermath of the 1967 war fundamentally changed the character of the Arab-Israeli conflict. Instead of settling the dispute, the conquest of the Occupied Territories created a stubborn diplomatic stalemate. On the ground, Israel constructed extensive military fortifications—most notably the Bar-Lev Line along the Suez Canal—and subsidized civilian settlements in the West Bank and Gaza, cementing Israeli presence in the territories. In the Arab world, the humiliation of conventional defeat convinced Palestinians that Arab state governments would never liberate their land, accelerating the rise of independent guerrilla organisations like the PLO. [4.2] United Nations Resolution 242 remained the recognized framework for all future Middle East peace diplomacy for the next thirty years, but in the late 1960s, it proved completely incapable of bridging the divide. With Arab governments adhering strictly to the "Three Noes" of Khartoum and Israel refusing any unilateral withdrawal without direct peace treaties, the stage was set for the continuous artillery duels of the War of Attrition and, ultimately, the surprise assault of the 1973 Yom Kippur War.

Q4. Explain the importance of UN Security Council Resolution 242 (1967) for Middle East peace diplomacy. [8 marks]

L4: KT 2.4: The Rise of Palestinian Resistance: The PLO, Black September & Munich (1968–1972)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Explain the significance of the Battle of Karameh (1968) for Palestinian morale and Arafat's rise.
- [ ] Describe the events of Black September in Jordan (1970) and explain why the PLO was expelled.
- [ ] Analyse the 1972 Munich Olympics massacre and evaluate its international impact.

> *In September 1970, Palestinian militants blew up three hijacked airliners in the Jordanian desert. Two years later, hooded gunmen scaled an Olympic fence in Munich. Having lost faith in Arab armies, Palestinians took their fight to the global stage.*

Recall & Retrieval (Prior Learning: KT1 & KT2.3)

1. What was the name of the diplomatic formula established by UN Resolution 242 in November 1967?

2. What were the famous "Three Noes" declared by Arab leaders at the Khartoum Conference in 1967?

3. Name three of the five territories captured by Israel during the June 1967 Six Day War.

4. Approximately how many Palestinian refugees fled across the River Jordan into Jordan after the 1967 war?

5. Which Palestinian guerrilla organisation was founded by Yasser Arafat in the late 1950s?

6. What does the acronym PLO stand for?

7. In what city was the PLO founded in January 1964?

8. Which Egyptian President expelled UN peacekeepers and closed the Straits of Tiran in May 1967?

9. What was the name of the armistice line drawn between Israel and its Arab neighbours in 1949?

10. Which international organisation partitioned Palestine in November 1947 under Resolution 181?

Vocabulary Check

Spot the Deliberate Error: *Read the statement below. One historical fact or vocabulary concept has been deliberately falsified. Underline the error and explain the accurate historical reality below:*

Fedayeen | Battle of Karameh (1968) | PFLP | Dawson's Field (1970) | Black September (1970) | Munich Olympics (1972)

Challenge: Write ONE statement containing a deliberate historical misconception using **Fedayeen** or **Battle of Karameh (1968)**. Identify and correct the error:

Teacher Model / Historical Correction:

[1.1] The disastrous defeat of Arab state armies in the 1967 Six Day War destroyed Palestinian confidence in Arab leaders like Gamal Abdel Nasser. For nineteen years, Palestinians had waited for regular Arab armies to defeat Israel and restore their homeland. After 1967, young Palestinians decided that they had to take their destiny into their own hands, joining independent armed guerrilla organisations known as *fedayeen* ("those who sacrifice themselves"). The defining turning point occurred on 21 March 1968 at the town of Karameh inside Jordan. When a large Israeli armored force crossed the border to destroy guerrilla camps, Palestinian fighters belonging to Yasser Arafat's Fatah movement chose to stand and fight alongside Jordanian artillery rather than retreating into the surrounding hills. [1.2] The Battle of Karameh was a military victory for Israel, which destroyed the guerrilla base and killed over 100 fighters. However, Palestinian guerrillas inflicted unusually heavy casualties on the Israeli Defence Forces, killing 28 Israeli soldiers and disabling several tanks. Across the Arab world, Karameh was celebrated as a

legendary moral victory—the first time Arab fighters had stood their ground and inflicted serious losses on the Israeli army. Thousands of young men volunteered to join Fatah in the weeks that followed. In February 1969, Yasser Arafat was elected Chairman of the PLO, cementing Fatah's leadership and transforming the PLO from a corrupt diplomatic group controlled by Arab heads of state into an independent, armed national liberation movement.

Q1. Using paragraphs [1.1] and [1.2], explain why the Battle of Karameh was a turning point for Palestinian national identity and how it led to Yasser Arafat taking control of the PLO.

Source A: Archival Photograph: PFLP Militants Detonating Hijacked Commercial Airliners at Dawson's Field, Jordan (12 September 1970) *Archival Evidence • Expand ▼*

[2.1] By 1970, the growing strength of Palestinian guerrilla groups inside Jordan had created an unsustainable crisis. Armed guerrillas operated as a "state within a state" in the capital city of Amman, setting up roadblocks, carrying loaded assault rifles in public, refusing to pay Jordanian taxes, and ignoring police authority. Radical Marxist splinter groups, most notably George Habash's Popular Front for the Liberation of Palestine (PFLP), believed that small-scale border raids would never force Western superpowers to pay attention to Palestine. The PFLP pioneered international airplane hijackings to capture world headlines. In early September 1970, PFLP militants staged their most daring operation, hijacking four Western commercial airliners bound for New York. [2.2] Three of the hijacked aircraft (Swissair, TWA, and BOAC flights) were forced to land at Dawson's Field, a remote desert airstrip in northern Jordan. After holding over 300 passengers hostage for several days, the hijackers released the passengers and blew up the multi-million-dollar airliners in front of international media cameras. (Source A) shows the charred, smoking ruins of the blown-up passenger planes at Dawson's Field, an act of defiance that directly threatened the authority and sovereignty of King Hussein of Jordan. Realising that his kingdom was descending into anarchy, King Hussein declared martial law on 17 September 1970. The Jordanian army launched an all-out offensive against Palestinian militias in Amman in a bloody civil war known as "Black September." After ten days of heavy fighting that cost thousands of lives, Palestinian fighters were crushed, and by mid-1971, the PLO and its forces were completely expelled from Jordan, relocating their headquarters to southern Lebanon.

Q2. Using Source A and paragraphs [2.1]–[2.2], explain how the Dawson's Field hijackings led directly to the Black September crackdown and the expulsion of the PLO to Lebanon.

Source B: Archival Primary Photograph: Masked Black September Gunman on the Balcony at Munich Olympic Village (5 September 1972) *Archival Evidence • Expand ▼*

[3.1] Driven into exile in Lebanon and burning for revenge against King Hussein and Israel, radical Palestinian militants formed a covert terrorist cell calling itself "Black September." On 5 September 1972, during the Summer Olympic Games in Munich, West Germany, eight heavily armed Black September militants scaled the wire fence of the Olympic Village. They forced their way into the quarters of the Israeli Olympic team, immediately shooting dead a weightlifter and a wrestling coach who tried to resist, and taking nine other Israeli athletes, coaches, and referees hostage. [3.2] The militants demanded the immediate release of 234 Palestinian prisoners held in Israeli jails. Israeli Prime Minister Golda Meir flatly refused, stating that giving in to blackmail would endanger Israelis and Jewish people worldwide. German authorities arranged to transport the terrorists and hostages by helicopter to the nearby Fürstenfeldbruck airbase, pretending they would be flown to Egypt, while secretly preparing a police ambush. However, the

German rescue attempt was disastrously mismanaged: snipers had no night-vision equipment or radio communication, and armored vehicles arrived late. In the resulting firefight on the tarmac, a terrorist tossed a grenade into one helicopter, while another gunman shot the hostages in the second helicopter. All nine remaining Israeli hostages, five terrorists, and one German police officer were killed. (Source B) shows the chilling photograph of a masked Black September gunman on the Olympic village balcony, an image beamed live by television into hundreds of millions of living rooms around the globe. In response, Golda Meir authorized the Mossad intelligence agency to track down and assassinate the planners of the massacre in a covert campaign known as "Operation Wrath of God."

Q3. Using Source B and paragraphs [3.1]–[3.2], explain how the Munich attack brought international publicity to the Palestinian issue, and analyse Israel's response.

[4.1] The turn to international terrorism between 1968 and 1972 had deeply contradictory consequences for the Palestinian struggle. On the one hand, spectacular attacks like the Dawson's Field hijackings and the Munich Olympics forced the international community to acknowledge that the Palestinian problem was not simply a humanitarian refugee issue, but an unresolved political struggle for national self-determination. By 1974, the United Nations invited Yasser Arafat to address the General Assembly as the recognized representative of the Palestinian people. [4.2] On the other hand, terrorism caused severe strategic damage to the Palestinian national cause. In Jordan, reckless armed militancy brought about the catastrophe of Black September, costing thousands of Palestinian lives and depriving the PLO of its border with Israel. Internationally, the Munich massacre alienated Western governments and justified aggressive Israeli military reprisals. While violence won global headlines, it ultimately demonstrated that terrorism alone could never defeat Israel or achieve an independent state, prompting Yasser Arafat to gradually steer the PLO towards international diplomacy in the mid-1970s.

Q4. Explain one consequence of the Black September conflict in Jordan (1970) for the PLO. [4 marks]

L5: KT 2.5: The War of Attrition & The Yom Kippur War (1969–1973)

LEARNING OBJECTIVES

- [ ] Explain the nature of the War of Attrition and Anwar Sadat's strategic motivation for war.
- [ ] Describe how Egypt and Syria achieved tactical surprise on 6 October 1973 and breached Israeli defenses.
- [ ] Analyse the global impact of the war, including superpower confrontation and the OPEC oil embargo.

> *On 6 October 1973, while Israel observed its holiest fast day, 80,000 Egyptian soldiers crossed the Suez Canal using high-pressure water hoses to wash away Israeli sand ramparts. It was a war that brought the superpowers to nuclear alert and changed Middle Eastern history.*

Recall & Retrieval (Prior Learning: KT1 & KT2.4)

1. What was the name of the Israeli Olympic athletes' hostage crisis that occurred in September 1972?

2. Which Palestinian faction was led by Yasser Arafat from 1969 onwards?

3. In which Middle Eastern kingdom did the "Black September" civil conflict take place in 1970?

4. Which Arab monarch ordered his army to crush and expel Palestinian guerrilla factions in September 1970?

5. To which neighbouring country did the PLO relocate its main headquarters after being expelled from Jordan?

6. What was the name of the 1968 battle in Jordan that became a symbol of Palestinian armed resistance?

7. Which Egyptian leader died in September 1970 and was succeeded by Anwar Sadat?

8. What was the name of the fortified sand-barrier defensive line built by Israel along the east bank of the Suez Canal?

9. What was the number of the November 1967 United Nations Security Council Resolution that introduced "Land for Peace"?

10. Which vital international waterway remained closed to international shipping between 1967 and 1975?

Vocabulary Check

The Odd One Out: *Circle ONE term that does not belong with the others. Explain your reasoning: What historical connection links the other terms, and why is your chosen term different?*

War of Attrition | Bar-Lev Line | Anwar Sadat | Yom Kippur | OPEC Oil Embargo | Shuttle Diplomacy

Teacher Model / Pupil Reasoning:

[1.1] Following the 1967 war, Egyptian President Gamal Abdel Nasser refused to accept Israeli occupation of the Sinai Peninsula. In March 1969, Nasser launched the "War of Attrition"—a prolonged campaign of heavy artillery bombardments, commando raids, and aerial dogfights across the Suez Canal designed to inflict unsustainable casualties on the small Israeli army. In response, Israel constructed the "Bar-Lev Line," an elaborate chain of fortified concrete bunkers and massive sand ramparts over sixty feet high running the entire length of the canal. The War of Attrition dragged on until an American-brokered ceasefire in August 1970, which cost over 10,000 Egyptian and 360 Israeli lives without shifting the front lines by an inch. [1.2] When Nasser died of a heart attack in September 1970, he was succeeded by his vice-president, Anwar Sadat. Observers in Israel and Washington initially dismissed Sadat as a weak leader. However, Sadat possessed a bold, realistic strategic vision. He recognized that Egypt's economy was crumbling under immense military spending and that Israel would never surrender the Sinai Peninsula

through peaceful diplomacy while it enjoyed total military superiority. Sadat did not plan an impossible war to destroy Israel; instead, he planned a limited, high-intensity surprise offensive to cross the canal, seize a secure bridgehead in the Sinai, shatter the myth of Israeli invincibility, and force the American superpower to intervene and broker a comprehensive peace.

Q1. Using paragraphs [1.1] and [1.2], explain what the War of Attrition was and why Anwar Sadat decided to wage a limited war rather than trying to destroy Israel.

Source A: Archival Photograph: Egyptian Infantry and Armored Columns Crossing the Suez Canal (October 1973)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[2.1] On Saturday, 6 October 1973, at 2:00 pm, Egypt and Syria launched a coordinated surprise assault on two fronts. The timing was chosen with meticulous care: it was Yom Kippur, the holiest day in Judaism, when Israeli radio stations were silent, roads were empty, and many soldiers were home with their families or fasting in synagogues. It was also the Muslim holy month of Ramadan. In the north, 1,400 Syrian tanks surged across the Golan Heights armistice line, overwhelming thin Israeli defensive units. In the south, over 80,000 Egyptian infantrymen crossed the Suez Canal on assault rafts under cover of a massive 2,000-gun artillery bombardment. [2.2] The Egyptian army executed a brilliant engineering feat. Rather than using conventional explosives to clear the massive sand ramparts of the Bar-Lev Line, Egyptian engineers deployed high-pressure water turbines pumping water directly from the canal, washing away thousands of tons of sand in hours to create bridge ramps. (Source A) shows Egyptian infantry crossing the Suez Canal on pontoon bridges and planting the Egyptian flag on the captured ramparts. When Israeli jet fighters and tanks rushed forward to counter-attack, they were devastated by mobile Soviet-supplied surface-to-air missiles (SAM-6) and wire-guided anti-tank missiles (Saggers). In the first forty-eight hours of combat, Israel lost over 150 tanks and dozens of aircraft, plunging the Israeli leadership into panic.

Q2. Using Source A and paragraphs [2.1]–[2.2], explain how Egypt achieved surprise on Yom Kippur and how water monitors and Soviet missiles neutralized Israeli advantages.

Source B: Archival Photograph: Israeli Armored Vehicles and Tanks Crossing the Suez Canal to the West Bank (October 1973)

Archival Evidence • Expand ▼

[3.1] Facing critical shortages of ammunition and equipment, Israeli Prime Minister Golda Meir appealed urgently to the United States. US President Richard Nixon ordered a massive emergency military airlift, flying hundreds of transport planes loaded with tanks, artillery shells, and electronic countermeasures directly to Israeli airfields. Simultaneously, the Soviet Union launched an airlift to resupply Egypt and Syria. Having stabilized the northern front in fierce tank battles in the Golan Heights, Israeli armored divisions under General Ariel Sharon found an undefended seam between Egypt's Second and Third Armies. On the night of 15 October, Sharon's forces crossed to the western bank of the Suez Canal on pontoon rafts, establishing a bridgehead inside mainland Egypt. (Source B) shows Israeli tanks and armor crossing to the western bank, where they severed Egyptian supply lines and encircled Egypt's 30,000-strong Third Army. [3.2] As the military balance swung violently back towards Israel, the conflict triggered a global crisis. On 17 October, the Organisation of Petroleum Exporting Countries (OPEC), led by Saudi Arabia, deployed the "oil weapon." Arab nations cut oil production by 5% per month and placed a total oil embargo on the United States and the Netherlands. The price of crude oil quadrupled from $3 to nearly $12 a barrel, causing catastrophic petrol shortages, inflation, and economic panic across the Western world. Meanwhile, when the Soviet Union threatened to deploy airborne troops to save the surrounded

Egyptian Third Army, the United States placed its nuclear armed forces on worldwide DEFCON 3 alert. US Secretary of State Henry Kissinger flew urgently between Moscow, Tel Aviv, and Cairo, finally securing a binding UN ceasefire on 24 October 1973.

Q3. Using Source B and paragraphs [3.1]–[3.2], explain how the US and Soviet airlifts impacted the war and how the OPEC oil embargo affected Western nations.

[4.1] The Yom Kippur War of 1973 was a profound psychological and political earthquake for both sides. For Israel, although its army had recovered to surround enemy forces within fifty miles of Cairo and Damascus, the cost had been catastrophic: over 2,600 Israeli soldiers killed and the shattering of the nation's supreme confidence in military invincibility. A subsequent government inquiry (the Agranat Commission) forced the resignation of military chiefs and contributed to Prime Minister Golda Meir stepping down in 1974. [4.2] For Egypt, although militarily contained at the end, the war was celebrated as a monumental national victory. By successfully crossing the Suez Canal and standing toe-to-toe with the IDF, Egypt had wiped away the shame of 1967 and restored Arab pride. Crucially, this restored dignity gave Anwar Sadat the political authority he needed to negotiate with Israel as an equal. The war had proven to Israelis that occupying land did not guarantee security, while the OPEC oil crisis forced the United States to commit permanently to Middle Eastern peace diplomacy. The road was now open for Kissinger's shuttle diplomacy, Sadat's historic 1977 visit to Jerusalem, and the 1978 Camp David Accords.

Q4. Write a narrative account analysing the key events of the Yom Kippur War (October 1973). [8 marks] You may use the following in your answer: • The surprise attack on 6 October 1973 • The OPEC oil embargo You must also use information of your own.